

old piano in his uncle's house and began making up music of his own. Olivier received some private lessons, but his progress accelerated after the war, when the family moved to Paris. In 1919, aged just 10, he entered the Paris Conservatoire.

“ It is **possible to make sounds** on a **piano** that are more **orchestral** than those of an **orchestra.** ”

OLIVIER MESSIAEN

Messiaen's teachers at the Conservatoire included Paul Dukas and Marcel Dupré. Regarded as the finest organist of his generation, the latter had a particularly important influence. Under his tutelage, the organ superseded the piano as Messiaen's principal instrument, which was to play an important part in his career. In 1931, Messiaen was appointed chief organist at the church of La Ste-Trinité in Paris, a great honor for one so young. He often played there over the next 60 years, although he was careful not to use it for any of his more extravagant experiments. Messiaen reassured his curate in a letter: “In music, one always has to seek what is new, but reserve that for chamber and orchestral works in which fantasy is admissible.” Messiaen's employment at the church did, however, dovetail with his chief source of inspiration as a composer: his faith. A devout Catholic, he often claimed that he was “born believing.” Not surprisingly, this was reflected in his choice of material. His first published